

When I was twelve, we moved into a one-room kitchen flat in a newly constructed building not far from our chawl. Bauji had to really stretch himself financially to buy the flat. But he was determined to move out of the chawl, not so much out of any desire to move up the social ladder as much as from the realization that the chawl was not a place where his children should grow up. He was aware that I was moving around in wrong company.

The change of locality made little difference to my delinquent ways. By the time I was in the ninth standard, I had already tasted hard liquor and had taken a liking to the occasional cigarette. My buddies at school were Arthur and Shankar, both a year senior to me, but two years older in age, having flunked the ninth standard. Arthur was a violent boy, always spoiling for a brawl. Shankar was cool-headed, but the strongest of us and also the cruellest.

Shankar used to moonlight for Babu, brother of municipal corporator Kim Bahadur Thapa who was later killed in a gangwar in 1991. I was taller than most boys my age and of decent build too. But more importantly, I had what Shankar used to call 'daring'. Looking back, I shudder at the crazy things I did in those years.

Shankar ran petty errands for Babu, which meant intimidating hawkers who did not pay up, keeping a close watch on or beating up people at Babu's command, buying him groceries and other such things. Arthur and I assisted Shankar in his assignments.

I was an average student but was good at Maths. It was Bauji's cherished desire to see me become an engineer. He had not studied beyond the twelfth standard, but had a good technical bent of mind and was an expert at repairing gadgets, from radios to kitchen taps.

'You know, *beta*, seeing me fix a fault at the factory, trainee engineers often ask which engineering college I am from. I tell them that I am not an engineer, but some day my son will become one,' he said more than once at the dinner table.

But gradually, his hopes faded as word of my exploits slowly got to him. As with every father, there was the initial disbelief when he learnt of my misdeeds.

I was in standard ten when my father smelt alcohol on me. He had long suspected it but the reality unsettled him. Later that night I heard him tell Ma that unless he took some drastic steps, I would ruin my life and theirs